

Good Morning, Sun Country

By WILLIAM I. LATHAM

THE TRUE GOALS

*Teach us, Father, the true goals,
That riches and social position
And acclaim of fellows may not
Always bring happiness.
But that in knowing Thee,
In nature and in daily living,
And with a good helpmate,
A home centered on Thee
We may, of all men, find
Ourselves most blessed.
Bless our men and women in uniform. Amen.*

RELIGION AND THE U.S.

One of the criticisms leveled against The El Paso Times, in recent years, has been "You publish too much religious news."

I expect we do. We run a prayer on Page

1, a prayer at the beginning of this column each Sunday, an ad which daily features a reading from the Bible and a Saturday church page. I don't think that is too much but I may not be the one to judge.

Recently, glancing through a book on the Bicentennial, I found something which pointed out that, in our country, religion has always been a dominant factor. It was written by Deane Edwards. Here it is:



William I. Latham

RELIGION IN AMERICAN LIFE

Faith in God is woven into the fabric of our national life from the beginning.

When the first settlers landed on American soil at the spot which they named Jamestown after their sovereign, they carried with them the official admonition of the London Council for Virginia that "the way to prosper is to serve and fear God, for every plantation which our heavenly Father hath not planted shall be rooted out."

When the Pilgrim Fathers set foot at Plymouth, they worshipped God "with prayer and psalm."

When William Penn established his colony of Pennsylvania, among the many expressions of his Christian concern was this exclamation: "O that thou mayest be kept faithful to the God of thy mercies and in the life of righteousness be preserved to the end!"

So from the earliest year, the name of God was known and honored. As time rolled on to bring the stirring and critical days of the Revolution, it provided the impressive picture of the American commander-in-chief on his knees in fervent prayer at Valley Forge. It gave us also his memorable prayer after his inauguration as President in which he called upon God in humble supplication for the new nation.

When later years brought violent division in the nation, we find another great figure, about to take up his presidential duties, turning to his neighbors and friends fathered to bid him farewell and saying to them: "Trusting in Him who can go with me and remain with you, and be everywhere for good, let us confidently hope that all will yet be well. To His care commending you, as I hope in your prayers you will commend me, I bid you an affectionate farewell."

Instances multiply beyond number that evidence the strong religious convictions which influenced our leaders, molded our national ideals, and carried us successfully through many a crisis.

While it is true that the religious life of America had its ebbs and flow, it is also true that the undercurrents of religion were never lost and have proved to be a spiritual resource for individual and nation.

A SMALL WORLD

You have heard that old saying "It's a small world."

Sometimes I think it is true. Back on April 1, in this column, I wrote an account of my battalion's first action on the Rhine in 1945. It was Easter Sunday and we had one man killed.

The day I wrote that the "corporate team" from Gannett made its annual trip to El Paso. Heading that team was Allen H. Neuhaert, president and chief executive of Gannett. We had day-long sessions with the team and a dinner that night. The next morning the column appeared. The members of the team took copies of the Times with them when they boarded the plane to fly back to Rochester.

Imagine my surprise a few days later to receive this note from Neuhaert:

"Our visits with you were totally enjoyable — and when we boarded the plane at El Paso this morning and I read your column, I couldn't help wishing I had known about it last night."

"I, too, was in the 86th Division — Headquarters Company, 341st Infantry, Intelligence and Reconnaissance Platoon."

"We spent that early period, including Easter Sunday, in a warehouse on the west bank of the Rhine, working out of it."

"Anyway, your column brought back all the old memories and I hope some day we can sit down and swap lies about all of our achievements with the Blackhawk Division."

Later, while in Washington, I let Neuhaert read a copy of "We Was Up There," the account of the battalion's combat duty in Europe.

Through the years I have maintained contact with some members of my platoon but Neuhaert is the first man I have met in recent years who was in the same company — Headquarters and Headquarters Company, 341st Infantry, 86th Division. Small world, as I said before.

MORE PUBLICITY

El Paso gets publicity in the strangest places. Mrs. Alfred Braden, president of El Paso Pet Cemetery, brought me a copy of News And Views, the bi monthly publication of the National Association of Pet Cemeteries which included an article on the local cemetery named "Cemetery of the Month." It recounted events of 1975. The late Alfred Braden was a director of that association at the time of his death.

ANDY DROPS BY

Andy Cohen, longtime friend, dropped by to bring me a copy of a poem. Both of us agreed it was timely. How often we read about a friend's death and how often we regret not having taken time to visit him.

Here it is:

*Around the corner I have a friend,
In this great city that has no end.
But days go by, and weeks rush*

*on,
Before you know it a year is gone.
And you never see your old friend's*

*face,
'Cause life is a swift and terrible*

*race.
Tomorrow, say, I'm going to call on*

*Jim,
Just so he knows I'm thinking of*

*him.
But tomorrow comes and tomorrow*

*goes.
And the distance between us grows*

*and grows.
But he knows I like him just as*

*well
As in the days when I rang his bell*

And he rang mine; but we were

*younger then;
Now we are two tired, busy men.*

*Tired of trying to win some fame,
Tired of trying to make a name.*

Here comes a boy from over the

*way,
A telegram, sir, — "Jim died*

*today."
That's what we get and deserve in*

*the end,
Around the corner, a vanished*

friend.